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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

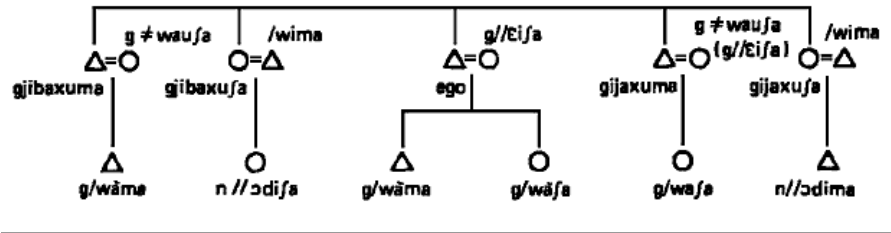
Coverage Date: 1950-1966

Place Coverage

G/wi, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): SOCIAL ORDER

Figure 7-16. Sibling group and offspring.



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Kin Relationships

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Community Structure

The G/wi kinship system is essentially concerned with ordering relationships between ascendants and descendants (Fig. 7-15), between siblings and between their offspring (Fig. 7-16), and between affines. In the context of band life, this range is usually more than sufficient to include band colleagues who are also kinsmen and will also include kinsmen in allied bands, which is the practical limit of the social life of most individuals. It is a system that permits easy fusion at a number of points because of its symmetry and nonexclusive nature. At the same time, its generalized, unspecialized, and nonhierarchical nature permits fission at almost any point outside the nuclear family. Kin, apart from those in the nuclear family, do not have particular and peculiar obligations to one another which might inhibit the division that takes place when interband migration occurs and when the band separates into constituent households. Fission is, in any case, attenuated by the system of band alliances, which maintains links between those who are separated by distance and seldom see each other.

*Ownership—Inheritance* A band's territory and its resources are not susceptible to ownership by man (despite the institution of owners), but are the property of the Supreme Being, *N!adima*. The band is the corporate holder of exclusive rights of occupation and exploitation, and the owners might be considered the administrators of this right on behalf of the band. Ownership by man is confined to exploited resources and their products (and imported commodities); in short, food, artifacts, and tobacco. The rights of ownership are encroached upon by the general pressure toward generosity and sharing and the particular demands of sharing with joking relatives. Nevertheless, these factors do not erase ownership; many people may borrow an item of property and, however little an owner may see of it, it is always identified as belonging to him.

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With the exception of beadwork, inheritance of property is precluded by the custom of breaking all of a deceased person's belongings on his grave and leaving them there to mark the grave. Beadwork is excluded and devolves, without formality, on the daughters of the deceased. There are no grades of status to be inherited, except possibly that of owner, which has already been discussed.

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